

A SAFE SPACE Miguel with the children of Hafiz Nagar

He had finally found his purpose: child welfare, protection and empowerment.

This became UTSAH, meaning inspiration in Assamese, the organisation Miguel formally registered in 2011. Starting with informal education sessions and cleanliness drives, UTSAH pivoted to structured legal intervention when during Holi in March 2013, it handled its first case of child sexual abuse, among the earliest prosecuted under the POCSO Act in the region. The conviction in 2014 placed UTSAH at the centre of Assam's child protection framework.

In 2017, UTSAH and the Assam Police jointly designed a structured programme focused on child-friendly policing. Formally launched in 2019 as the Assam Police Sishu Mitra Programme, it placed empathy at its core—training police personnel to interact with children without uniforms, ensure timely production before Child Welfare Committees, maintain proper documentation, coordinate with social workers and uphold justice.

In 2023, the Supreme Court upheld Sishu Mitra and UTSAH's founder as a shining example at annual stakeholders' consultations on child protection. Miguel could not have asked for a better validation. ■

SURVIVORSPEAK

"My daughter was 12 when an influential cardiologist in Guwahati sexually assaulted her. When confronted, he threatened us. UTSAH gave us the courage to fight back"

PARENT OF A CHILD SURVIVOR *assisted by UTSAH*